

The underrated brilliance of Tim Cook

I have seen Tim Cook up close thrice. The first time was when he arrived in India to open Apple's first retail store – navigating through the humidity and chaos of Mumbai with a lot of grace. Then, twice more at Apple Park in Cupertino: once at the iPhone 16 launch and again at last year's WWDC.

On all three occasions, despite the deafening roar of the “fanboy” crowds and the immense pressure of a trillion-dollar market cap, what stood out was his preternatural calm, a searing clarity in thought, and a genuine, boyish excitement about what was about to unfold.

This is a man who has spent over a decade leading one of the most talk-about tech companies in the world. He was tasked with the impossible job of following a visionary. And, Cook proved that a master steward can be just as transformative as an inventor.

In the Valley, tech leaders are rarely seen as humans. They are either gods or monsters. Look at the whiplash of Sam Altman's reputation – transitioning from a visionary sage to a suspected villain almost overnight. But, Tim Cook occupies a unique, quiet middle ground. He is perhaps the most criticised man in tech, yet, curiously, he has no real haters.

Architect of the post-Jobs Era

When Steve Jobs passed the baton in 2011, the tech world was skeptical. Jobs was the sorcerer. Cook was the supply-chain wizard. The narrative was simple: Apple's “soul” was gone, and the company would eventually stall. Instead, Cook performed a feat of corporate engineering that defied every pessimistic projection. Under his tenure, Apple has not just grown but it has transitioned from a hardware-first company to a services juggernaut.

The “Founder” CEO is a mythical figure. Erratic, visionary, and often difficult. The “Professional” CEO is usually seen as a placeholder. Efficient, sterile, and risk-averse.

Tim Cook broke that dichotomy. He proved



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that a non-founder could not only maintain a founder's vision but evolve it. His initial tenure saw the launch of products like Apple Watch and AirPods which have become multi-dollar businesses in their own right.

The most significant achievement wasn't a device: it was the ecosystem. Cook realised that if Apple owned the software (iOS), the services (iCloud, Music, Fitness+), and the silicon (M-series chips), they would create a “walled garden” so lush that no user would ever want to leave.

The calm amidst the critique

Cook's leadership style is the antithesis of the “move fast and break things” mantra. He is frequently criticised for being “boring” or for Apple's perceived lack of “innovation”. Critics point to the incremental updates of the iPhone or the slow rollout of foldable tech as signs of a stagnant company.

Yet, this criticism rarely turns into the visceral animosity directed at peers like Elon Musk or Mark Zuckerberg. Why? Because Cook has positioned himself not as a disruptor, but as a steward. During his time at Apple, privacy has been at the centre of almost every announcement. It has become the core pillar of Apple's branding. He won the trust. That too at a time when other big tech companies were failing at it.

Seeing him in India was a masterclass in his unique brand of soft power. He visited local temples, watched IPL cricket matches, and met with developers with a quiet curiosity. He turned Apple from a tech brand to a luxury brand. One that defined lifestyle.

As Cook steps down from his role, he can rest with the satisfaction that he took the most scrutinised job in the world and performed it with such consistent, quiet excellence that even his harshest critics have to respect the result. Steve Jobs might have been the man who invented the future, but Tim Cook is the man who made it work. **d**